Lesson 30 material: Narrative Paragraphs 1: Focus, Topic Sentence, Time Order and Past Tenses

Unit 5 Narrative Paragraphs (part I-V)

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Unit 5 Narrative Paragraphs

Learning Objectives

1. To learn what a narrative paragraph focuses on
2. To understand and practice narrative paragraphs with a focus on the use of time transitions, past tenses, descriptive vocabulary, and specific supporting details
3. To study narrative paragraphs through analyzing multiple models
4. To apply the writing process to plan and write narrative paragraphs

I. Warm – Up

(Picture: a man sitting on a chair at an airport)

a man sitting on a chair at an airport

Read Paragraph "My Worst Trip" and do the activities that follow.

My Worst Trip

My experiences at Miami Airport and during the flight to Chicago on September 29, 2007 were terrible because I could not understand English. I came from Mexico, and that was my first connecting trip out of my own country. After a long flight from my native country, I arrived at Miami Airport. I had been so excited walking in an American airport until a uniformed officer asked me something in English. I felt nervous because I did not speak English and did not know how to answer her questions. I just shook my head. I was not walking excitedly anymore because I realized that I did not speak the language. I already began to miss my own country! Suddenly, I looked at my watch, and it said 12:30 pm. I was so hungry that I needed to eat something. I had not eaten much on my first flight. I went to a small restaurant in the airport, looked at the pictures of the menu on the screen, and decided to have a coke and a sandwich. I could not see clearly or read what kind of sandwich that was, but it looked scrumptious[1]. I was just going to point to the picture and tell the waiter what I wanted. He came and spoke fast. Because I did not understand, I felt I had to say "Ok". Well, he gave me a different meal, and it cost me almost $20! This situation was awful[2]. I ate the meal in sad silence. I could not tell what it tasted like because I was tired and upset. Finally, I got on my flight to Chicago in the evening. On the plane, I wanted to drink water, but I did not know how to ask for it. I just stayed in my seat quietly and felt despondent[3]. In the end, I met my family at the airport in Chicago at 11:30 pm. On our way home, I told them about my nightmare. They comforted me, "Don't worry. All will be fine." However, I could not shake off the feeling that I had just had a rocky start[4] on my life in this new country. On that day, I made a promise to myself that I would have to study English really hard.

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1. Color code the paragraph:

Title – ***pink*** Background information **– *purple***

Topic sentence – ***red*** Beginning of the story – ***green***

Middle of the story – ***blue*** End of the story – ***green***

Transitions – ***yellow*** Concluding sentence(s) – ***red***

2. Discuss:

- What was your experience on your trip to the U.S.? Did you have a similar experience as the writer?
- Does the writer focus on telling a story, arguing for a controversial issue, or listing points to explain an idea?
- How is this paragraph similar to the ones you have studied in Unit 4 Enumerative Paragraphs?
- How is this paragraph different from the ones in Unit 4?
- What types of supporting ideas and details are used to explain the main idea?
- What do you like about this paragraph?
- How would you improve the paragraph?
- If you could ask the writer a question, what would you ask?

II. Focus of Narrative Paragraphs

Narration is a description of an experience, an event, a story, or a situation to show a point of view. You have already studied a narrative paragraph in Unit 3: My Valuable Life Lesson.

Narrative paragraphs have:

(Picture: an opened book with a leaf)

an opened book with a leaf

- a beginning: How did the story start?
- a middle: How did it progress?
- an ending: How did it end?

As you are telling a story in this type of paragraph, it is important to:

1. provide the background information about the story: what, who, when, where. If applicable, include the information on why and how. The information is usually given in the beginning.
2. use past tenses as you narrate a past experience or event.
3. guide the readers in understanding the event by using appropriate time expressions and arrange the information in **chronological order,** meaning time order.
4. use appropriate descriptive words and details to help the readers feel as if they were experiencing the event in person.

Exercise 1. Read the following paragraph titles. Which ones can be appropriate titles for narrative paragraphs? What will the paragraphs be about? Click "True" for appropriate narrative titles and "False" for non-narrative titles. You will get instant feedback after each sentence. The explanation is given in **blue.**

EXERCISE

1. 1. My First Day at Harper College (True / False)

EXERCISE

1. 2. Attending My Best Friend's Wedding (True / False)

EXERCISE

1. 3. My Dream House (True / False)

EXERCISE

1. 4. How to Register for Online Classes (True / False)

EXERCISE

1. 5. Reasons for Taking a Yoga Class (True / False)

EXERCISE

1. 6. My First Black Friday Shopping Trip (True / False)

EXERCISE

1. 7. A Memorable Morning at the Beach (True / False)

EXERCISE

1. Different Types of Friends (True / False)

III. Topic Sentence in Narration

Read Paragraph "My Worst Trip" again. How does the writer start the paragraph? The beginning contains the topic sentence and background information.

Parts for the Beginning of the Paragraph	Ideas
What (topic)	my experiences at Miami Airport and during the flight to Chicago
Controlling Idea	terrible
Who	I
When	September 29, 2007, after a long flight from my native country
Where	Miami Airport and on the plane to Chicago
Why (if applicable)	I could not understand English.
How (if applicable)	–
Ways to Write the Beginning	My experiences at Miami Airport and during the flight to Chicago on September 29, 2007 were terrible because I could not understand English. I came from Mexico, and that was my first connecting trip out of my own country. (2 sentences)

Study one more example:

Parts for the Beginning of the Paragraph	Ideas
What (topic)	a shopping trip
Controlling Idea	exhausting
Who	my sister and I
When	Black Friday, 2019

Where	Woodfield Mall		
Why (if applicable)	to get good deals on Christmas gifts for family and friends		
How (if applicable)	–		
Ways to Write the Beginning	My sister and I had an exhausting[5] shopping trip in the Woodfield Mall. It was Black Friday, 2019. We wanted to get good deals on Christmas gifts for our family and friends. *(3 sentences)*	On Black Friday in 2019, my sister and I had an exhausting shopping trip in the Woodfield Mall. We wanted to get good deals on Christmas gifts for our family and friends. *(2 sentences)*	To get good deals on Christmas gifts for our family and friends, my sister and I had an exhausting shopping trip in the Woodfield Mall on Black Friday in 2019. *(1 sentence)*

Exercise 2. Use the above examples as models. Fill in the information for the next three topics. In #3, you think of a topic of your own. Try writing your topic sentence with background information in one, two, or three sentences.

#1

Parts for the Beginning of the Paragraph	Ideas
What (topic)	My first visit to Harper College
Controlling Idea	
Who	
When	
Where	
Why (if applicable)	
How (if applicable)	
Ways to Write the Beginning	

#2

Parts for the Beginning of the Paragraph	Ideas
What (topic)	My family's most important day
Controlling Idea	
Who	
When	
Where	
Why (if applicable)	
How (if applicable)	
Ways to Write the Beginning	

#3

Parts for the Beginning of the Paragraph	Ideas
What (topic)	
Controlling Idea	
Who	
When	
Where	
Why (if applicable)	
How (if applicable)	
Ways to Write the Beginning	

IV. Supporting Ideas in Chronological Order and with Time Transitions

Chronological Order

The information in the middle of the paragraph is going to be the main part of the story. All the events are arranged chronologically. What happened first is written first, what happened next is explained next, and so on. One way to make sure of the correct order is to draw a timeline. This could be used as a brief outline for a paragraph. Below is a timeline for an interview experience:

(Picture: interview outline)

interview outline

Time Transitions

Another important aspect of narration is to use appropriate time expressions. They are transitions to guide the readers through the narration. You have already learned different transitions in Unit 3 Parts and Characteristics of a Good Paragraph and Unit 4 Enumerative Paragraphs. (*For reviews, open Unit 3 here and Unit 4 here.*)

Here are some time transitions. As you study them, pay attention to their punctuation.

Adverbs	*(in the beginning of a sentence – comma after them)*	Other adverbs and adverbial phrases	*(in the beginning of a sentence – comma after them)*	*(at the end of a sentence – no comma)*	Prepositional phrases	*(in the beginning of a sentence – comma after them)*	*(at the end of a sentence – no comma)*					
First,	Second,	Next,	Meanwhile,	Then (usually no comma after it)	Finally,	Lastly,	...	Right away,	Immediately,	Suddenly,	Quickly,	Soon,
Dependent clauses	*(before independent clauses – comma after them)*	*(after independent clauses – no comma)*	Complete sentences	*(period after them)*								
When I woke up,	While I was driving,	Until it was midnight,	Since he started the semester,	As it was happening,	As soon as they arrived home,	Before he left for work,	After the test was over,	...	Time went by quickly.	This was not the end of the ordeal.	Surprises continued.	Misfortune goes hand in hand[6].

Review Paragraph “My Worst Trip” in the beginning of this unit and discuss how the writer uses a variety of time transitions.

Read the new paragraph “My Memorable Interview” below. It is developed based on the timeline above. The time transitions are underlined. Discuss:

1. How does the writer begin the paragraph? What is the topic sentence? What is the controlling idea? What is the background information (what, who, when, where)?
2. Does the paragraph follow chronological order?
3. How are different types of time transitions used with different punctuations? (underlined)

My Memorable Interview

In my last year of high school in Japan, I learned an important lesson from a memorable interview. I had applied to the Social Welfare Department of the college that I wanted to enter. To be accepted, I had to pass an interview and answer questions about a book the college professors had assigned. The book, What is the True Wealth, was a very famous book among the people studying social welfare in Japan. One month before the interview, I read the book but understood the topic only superficially[7]. To help myself understand the topic better, I then bought another book that described the current social situation in Japan. After reading it many times, I was able to understand the topic of social welfare more clearly. In the middle of February, I flew to the college for the interview. It was not a cold day, but I had chills because of tension. I had never visited the prefecture where the college was located, so I felt the strain I had never felt before. The interview day arrived. The applicants were called in one by one from the waiting room. As soon as my name was called, I took a deep breath before entering with a smile. The interview room was small, with six professors sitting across the table. It appeared to be a normal interview situation, but when five cards were put side by side on the table, I realized that it was not! I could not understand what the cards were for. My nervousness grew. One professor instructed, “Please choose one card on the desk. You will see our first question there about the assigned book.” It was like a card game! Fortunately, I answered the question calmly and clearly. During the interview, I expressed my opinions with confidence, thanks to the two books which I had read. At the end of the interview, one professor asked me, “Have you read another book besides our assigned one?” At that time, I thought, “Good for me!” I spoke about my additional book and explained why I had chosen it, what I had learned from it, and how it had helped me with the interview. The professors looked impressed. I was so glad that I almost jumped for joy. They nodded to me and to each other. That afternoon, I flew back home, feeling happy. From this experience, I have learned a lesson essential to my success. It is important to prepare elaborately[8] before an important event. Hard work in advance would give me confidence and help me in unexpected situations.

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Exercise 3. Read Paragraph “The Day My Daughter Was Born” and discuss:

1. How does the writer begin the paragraph? What is the topic sentence? What is the controlling idea? What is the background information (what, who, when, where, why)?
2. Does the paragraph follow chronological order?
3. Underline the time transitions. How are different types of time transitions used with different punctuations?

The Day My Daughter Was Born

The day I met my daughter Ela has been the most significant day in my life. When I was in my 38th week of pregnancy, my husband and I went to the hospital for a routine pre-natal exam. While the doctor was checking me, she said, “We have to take the baby.” We were so shocked. If I had not had a problem, she would not have said such a thing. Right away, she started to explain my problem. My daughter could not move herself because there was not enough water in my womb. Upon hearing this, I wanted to go back to my house to bring the baby stuff, but she did not allow me. My husband was little panicked, for he did not know what to do. Actually, I was so scared and also excited at the same time. My daughter was coming to my life! Our family had been waiting for her arrival for a long time, and we could not wait to take her into our arms. In the next ten minutes, the doctor did some tests on me and took me to the surgery room. I was not aware how many minutes or hours had passed. When I opened my eyes, everything had already finished. My first question was if she was OK. My doctor reassured me, “Don’t worry. She is OK”. After that, the medical staff took me to my room. All my family members were waiting eagerly there. I asked my husband if he had seen our daughter. He said no. We could not wait to see her, and we were so happy, for she was born without any problem. Everybody in the room was happy and asking how I was feeling. I had totally forgotten myself! Soon, the doctor brought her to the room, and I will never forget the moment when I laid my eyes on her for the first time. I cried so much from happiness. There was my little baby Ela, so tiny and soft, and most important all, so beautiful! Her “baby smell” was the most heart-warming scent. My husband’s face was full of joyful pride. Everyone wanted to hold Ela for a second but stopped as she was sleeping soundly. At that moment, I understood that my life would change forever because of this precious new life. I promised myself and her that I would always be by her side.

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V. Past Tenses in Narration

In most narrative paragraphs, you are describing past events, so you need to use mostly past tenses even though present and future tenses are also possible in some parts of the paragraph. Past tenses include simple past, past progressive, past perfect, and past perfect progressive, and future past. However, the most common one is the simple past.

There are detailed explanations and practice in verb tenses from Unit 11 through Unit 14 in this book. (Open Unit 11 Present Tenses, Unit 12 Past Tenses, Unit 13 Future Tenses, Unit 14 Mixed Tenses here.)

Review paragraphs “My Worst Trip”, “My Memorable Interview”, and “The Day My Daughter Was Born”. Underline all the past tense verbs and discuss how these verbs are used.

Read another new paragraph “A significant Meeting” below and discuss:

1. What is the topic sentence? What is the controlling idea?
2. What is the background information (what, who, when, where)?
3. Does the writer explain the event in chronological order?
4. How are different types of time transitions used?
5. Underline all the verbs in past tenses. Why are some verbs in past perfect (bold-faced), one in past progressive (bold-faced), and one in simple future (bold-faced)?

A Significant Meeting

(Picture: a hand holding pink and blue heart-shaped lollipop candy)

a hand holding pink and blue heart-shaped lollipop candy

My first meeting with my future husband in real life on March 18, 2017 was so significant that it changed my life. This was my first visit to the U.S.A when I met Sergey. We **had communicated** and seen each other only through the Internet before that. Our meeting happened in beautiful New York City. The smell of early spring, with blooming trees, sunny weather, and breathtaking views of this city, reinforced my romantic mood. I woke up very early to prepare for the meeting that was supposed to happen at breakfast. I arrived at the restaurant before 10 am. 10 am was not a perfect time for a romantic date, but we **had planned** to spend the whole day together and visit sights. Just then, Sergey called to apologize that he **had overslept** on his flight to New York and would not arrive until 11 pm. I became very angry and disappointed. I could not believe how a person could approach[9] such an important event so irresponsibly[10]. As a result, I assumed[11] that he would not be my destiny and my second half. When I arrived back at the hotel, I suddenly noticed a man standing with flowers and staring at me with a guilty look. He **was wearing** a formal gray suit with a matching tie. After a couple of seconds, I realized this man was Sergey! He **had gotten** a few transfers to arrive earlier than expected. I was so surprised to see him at that moment. I did not know whether to be joyful or angry, but I instantly forgot about the morning case. Of course, I gave him one star for diligence[12]. During our live communication, all invisible borders were erased. We quickly connected and understood each other. His surprises did not end at our lunch. He gave me a helicopter flight over the city! I was in heaven with happiness and beauty around me. In addition, Sergey had another surprise at dinner. He produced two tickets, for the most anticipated fight show of the year by my favorite boxer Gennady Golovkin in the famous Madison Square. I could not believe that another dream would come true that day. At the end of that fantastic day, I came to realize that my future husband was very attentive[13]. He **had remembered** everything that I loved and dreamed about. He fulfilled my one desire after another. Sergey was like a genie[14], and I possessed his lamp. By the end of our first day together, I **had decided** to give him all stars and pluses. Our meeting transformed[15] my whole life, and these first happy moments **will remain** forever in my memories.

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Exercise 4. Read Paragraph “Meeting My Best Friends” and fill in each blank with the correct verb tense. When you finish this exercise, you can click “Check” to see how you did. You can retry or see all the answers. The first one is an example.

EXERCISE

Meeting My Best Friends I still feel (feel) excited when I remember the day I _____ (meet) my best friends. It _____ (be) spring 2013. At that time, my family and I _____ (live) in an apartment building in a town by a small airport. That day, I _____ (walk) outside with my daughter. Then, I _____ (see) a woman and a man moving their furniture into the building. At first, I _____ (think) they _____ (be) Russian because I _____(hear) the man speak in the Russian language. Both of them _____ (be) tall and about 30-35 years old. She

_____ (have) blonde hair and green eyes. He _____ (have) dark hair. We _____ (say) Hi to each other, and the woman _____ (walk) over to introduce herself and her husband. Her name _____ (be) Bella, and her husbands' name _____(be) Alex. They _____ (be) from Bulgaria. I _____ (introduced) my daughter and myself. I _____ (tell) them that I _____ (be) from Uzbekistan, my name _____ (be) Nargiza, and I _____ (speak) Russian. The language _____ (make) our conversation easier as we _____ (can) communicate in Russian. As it _____ (be) a moving day, they _____ (be) very busy, but Bella _____ (invite) us to go visit them any time the following week. In the years that followed, we _____ (become) not only good neighbors but also good friends. It _____ (be) almost ten years since we first _____ (meet). I _____ (be) very grateful to that day because I _____ (meet) my best friends. By N. Mamurova (student), ESL Writing III, Harper College. U sed with permission.